

Games People Play

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ABSTRACT

An academic and public library collaborate on a tabletop gaming event for the whole community.

KEYWORDS

academic libraries; board games; collaboration; public libraries

Games bring people together. For years, we at Rodney A. Briggs Library at the University of Minnesota, Morris, have hosted monthly game nights and have invited students to come play tabletop games such as Dixit and Codenames. Although a staff of five librarians all participate in this event, I am the primary librarian who is responsible for planning and coordinating this popular activity. This past January I tried something new that reached beyond the confines of our small university campus. Instead of focusing only on our students, I expanded the scope and set up a special Game Day at the local public library. Why? Because “including gaming programs in libraries helps keep libraries current” (Werner, 2013, p. 800) and can bring patrons through the library doors who might not otherwise come. Partnerships also tend to expand a potential audience and can foster future collaboration.

I first reached out to the new director of the Morris Public Library and asked her whether she would be interested in collaborating on a tabletop gaming event. Knowing that she was a Morris Public Library board member, I was aware that the director was interested in reaching out to the community and attracting underserved segments of the population. She was also known for being innovative and energetic. Almost immediately, the director signaled her interest in pursuing a joint gaming venture between the two libraries, and we began planning.

From the beginning, it was important for us to make the Game Day event inclusive. We wanted everyone to feel comfortable and welcome, including families, young adults, children, college students, and adults. We also knew that teenagers would be the toughest group to entice to attend the Game Day event. To attract the most diverse gamers, we made sure to include a large array of games for both young and old patrons. Our focus was on board games and card games because we did not have the resources for video

games. Tabletop games are in the middle of a renaissance and are very popular. Sales of hobby games in the United States and Canada reached nearly 1.2 billion in 2015 according to ICv2 (Griepp, 2016) an online trade magazine that covers pop culture products for retailers.

Many tabletop titles came from Briggs Library's extensive collection and from games the other librarians and I personally owned, including Risk, Monopoly, checkers, chess, Clue, Cranium, Forbidden Island, Dominion, Exploding Kittens, Apples to Apples, Bananagrams, and Welcome to the Dungeon. Because this was a family-friendly event, I left some of the adult-orientated games such as Cards Against Humanity in the library. One rule that we followed whenever possible was to keep it simple. As Werner mentions in the article, "Bringing Them In: Developing a Gaming Program for the Library," it is wise to "focus on games that can be completed quickly, this keeps patrons from getting bored or being unable to finish their game during the program" (2013, p. 792).

Free food is one of the best ways to encourage people to come to an event, and, for gamers, this is doubly true. "Any gamer will tell you that large amounts of junk food are a necessity to their very existence. If you are not stocked with the basic three—soda chips, and cookies—be very, very worried" (King, 2007, p. 510). For our first joint Game Day, we planned to provide pizza, snacks, and soda. The Friends of the Morris Public Library and Briggs Library Associates agreed to pay for the refreshments, which helped greatly, given that there is no budget for gaming activities in either library. An ample supply of cups, plates, and napkins was also purchased.

To maximize the number of participating community members, we decided early on to host the event at the public library. The Morris Public Library has a large meeting room spacious enough to accommodate 40 people comfortably with a door that can be closed to help contain the noise. The library building itself is centrally located, making it easy for community members to join. Having Game Day at the university library would have meant few, if any, community members in attendance because Morris residents are often reluctant about venturing onto campus. Our town/gown divide is quite pronounced. Locals often refer to the University of Minnesota, Morris, campus as being on a hill, which only increases the perceived separation. The irony is that the university is only negligibly on higher ground and shares this alpine altitude with the local public schools. Because these two spheres can be somewhat isolated, having a joint gaming event with the university library reaching out to its public counterpart is beneficial to overcoming barriers.

We included our partnership prominently in all publicity material, provided examples of games and mentioned that there would be free pizza. The poster design was colorful and inviting, because the public library director, who is also an artist, helped design it. Then, we posted

advertisements around town and on campus. After checking the community calendar for any conflicting events, we scheduled our event for the final Saturday in January from 11:00 a.m. until 5:00 p.m., when the library closes. We publicized the event in the local newspaper, on various social media platforms, on both library websites, and on the radio. Holding the event on a Saturday made sense to us because we thought members of the community would be more likely to participate on a weekend rather than on a weekday evening in the middle of winter.

Even widespread publicity does not guarantee a successful event. As I carried armloads of games into the public library and set up tables, I wondered whether anyone would attend. Would we get a handful of hardcore gamers and a lot of leftover pizza? Before long, the answer was clear; people were excited about the event as they filled the community room to capacity. More tables were hurriedly set up. I scurried from group to group, helping participants decide on a game, explaining rules, and even joining in if a certain number of players was required. Looking around after a quick game of *Welcome to the Dungeon* with some elementary students was finished, I was pleased at the variety of people who attended. There were college students, adults from the community and university, and several younger kids. The only group that did not have much representation was teenagers. Even so, Game Day was a resounding success. Gamers devoured pizzas hungrily, and tables remained full the entire afternoon. Best of all, people really enjoyed themselves. If someone looked slightly lost and did not know what to play, either the director or I would try and connect him or her with a good game.

One thing about games: They do not generally adhere to a rigid schedule. Because of this, several groups were still playing by the time the library closed. We simply reminded them that the library was closing and that they would have to wrap things up. It helped that the library director was flexible about staying open a few extra minutes to get everyone out the door. When the last child was finally picked up by their parents, we breathed a sigh of relief at a job well done.

Although we were very pleased with the turnout and reception to our first Game Day, we would do several things differently the next time around. Having more games aimed at younger elementary school children was definitely a priority. We were simply overwhelmed with the number of young children and did not have nearly enough games suitable for their age group. Part of the reason for this was that many of our games came from the academic Briggs Library and tended to have an adult or teen focus. Games such as *Trouble*, *Battleship*, *Life*, and *Candyland* would alleviate our deficit in this area. BoardGameGeek is a useful online source for more game titles. Next time, we might borrow games from friends or colleagues, or even buy them used.

We still need to attract more teenagers to our Game Day event. Few young adults attended despite extensively publicizing the event, including on social media. In the future, we plan to brainstorm other ways of communicating with this group, perhaps even targeting them more pointedly in the advertisements. Identifying teen gamers would give us possible insight into what would entice them to attend a library event. Perhaps we could hold a special gaming event just for their demographic.

Later this spring we plan to have another Game Day, making it even better than the first one. Because we do not want to wear out our welcome with our Friends organizations, we may not offer free pizza to patrons and provide only snacks and soda. If only we could pass “Go” and “Collect \$200”! Every event is a roll of the dice, but we think we are off to a pretty good start.

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